

What else to watch: *Death Takes a Holiday* (1934) ■ *The Virgin Spring* (1960) ■ *Through a Glass Darkly* (1961) ■ *The Silence* (1963) ■ *Winter Light* (1963) ■ *Hour of the Wolf* (1968) ■ *Cries and Whispers* (1972) ■ *Love and Death* (1975)

“What will happen to us who want to believe, and cannot?”

Antonius Block / *The Seventh Seal*

a crisis of faith. Whereas the Almighty refuses to show Himself, Death (Bengt Ekerot) turns out to be a certainty with a fondness for morbidly funny one-liners. “Appropriate, don’t you think?” says the Grim Reaper when he chooses black in a game of chess—a game that the knight must win if he wants to live. It is Antonius who suggests the contest, a battle between black and white, darkness and light, death and life.

Playing for his life

The image of the knight and Death playing chess on the beach has become one of the most iconic—and imitated—in the history of cinema. It is a starkly monochrome vignette, the absence of color symbolic of the absence of God. The world of Ingmar Bergman’s movie is drained of life and vitality: the water that laps the shore is slate gray, the sky above it smudged with dark clouds; the faces of God’s abandoned subjects are flinty, bloodless, and unsmiling, while Death’s is chalk white. Antonius already resembles the carved stone effigy on a Crusader’s tomb.

There are two flickers of hope in this miserable landscape: Jof (Nils Poppe) and

his wife Mia (Bibi Andersson). They are traveling players, and they have a baby son, Mikael, who is their hope for the future. Jof and Mia are creators—of both art and life—and as such they are the enemies of Death, who only knows how to destroy. When the knight encounters them on the road to his castle, Death not far behind, he finds comfort in the couple’s laughter and lust for life. In fact, he is reminded of Joseph and Mary from the Bible—could these performers be emissaries of God?

Where is God?

The grim, austere imagery and obsession with biblical allegory in *The Seventh Seal* (the title

was taken from the apocalyptic Book of Revelation) has its roots in Bergman’s childhood: as the son of a Lutheran pastor, he was surrounded by religious art from a young age. The director was haunted by memories of the crude yet graphic representations of Bible stories that could be found in the woodcuttings of rural churches and households. As a filmmaker, he dedicated his career to asking the same, unanswerable question over and over again: where is God? »

Squire Jöns (Gunnar Björnstrand) saves a girl (Gunnel Lindblom) from a rapist. He is a just man, but tires of the venality of human beings.

